

JSM 2024 Graduate Student Mentoring Session

The graduate student mentoring session is organized by the ASA Section on the Statistics and the Environment and is held during the Joint Statistical Meetings, 2024. The session will be held in a hybrid format (in-person and online) and presents a great opportunity for graduate students (especially those attending JSM) to learn from and interact with the mentors of the session who are experienced members of the ENVR community. Our mentors come from various backgrounds, including academia, industry, and government. In the session, each speaker gives a short (around 10 mins) presentation on different aspects of mentoring, career opportunities, and general advice on developing a successful career as a junior researcher. This is followed by a Q&A session with the students.

Signup here: <https://forms.gle/U1Pfp4hbb4cpvtVq8>

Learn more about the mentors below.

Mentors

Dr. Julie Bessac

National Renewable Energy Laboratory (NREL)



Julie Bessac is a computational statistician at the Computational Science Center at the National Renewable Energy Laboratory (NREL), Golden, CO. She is also an adjunct professor at Virginia Tech, Blacksburg, VA, where she is located. Prior to joining NREL, Julie Bessac was a post-doctoral appointee and a research scientist in the Mathematics and Computer Science Division at Argonne National Laboratory, Argonne, IL. Her research focuses on the statistical modeling, forecasting and uncertainty quantification for diverse applications, as for instance

geophysical processes, data compression, and material science. Julie Bessac is an awardee of the US Department of Energy Office of Science Early Career Research Program.

Dr. Mauricio (Moe) Campos
Verisk Extreme Event Solutions



Coming from Costa Rica, Moe got his bachelors in Statistics at the University of Costa Rica. There, he worked as an instructor in the Department of Statistics for 2 years, after which he pursued his PhD in Statistics from the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, obtaining his degree in August of last year. He worked in several spatial statistics applications in UIUC as well as Sandia National Lab. His work includes data fusion of distinct sources of evidence for glacial refugia in Alaska, decomposing solar-induced fluorescence measurements for different crops in Illinois and combining meteorological data from different resolutions worldwide. He's also collaborated in various health-related publications regarding COVID-19 and food insecurity in the US, as well as on the use of psychotropic drugs in Costa Rica. At the beginning of the year, Moe joined Verisk Extreme Event Solutions in Boston, a multidisciplinary environment where he has been able to apply his spatial statistical knowledge in the development of several catastrophe models relating to severe thunderstorms in the US.

Dr. Raphaël Huser

King Abdullah University of Science and Technology (KAUST), Saudi Arabia



Raphaël Huser is an Associate Professor of Statistics in the Computer, Electrical and Mathematical Sciences and Engineering (CEMSE) Division at the King Abdullah University of Science and Technology (KAUST), Saudi Arabia, where he leads the Extreme Statistics (XSTAT) research group. He started his career at KAUST initially as a Postdoctoral Research Fellow in 2014, and was later appointed Assistant Professor of Statistics, before transitioning to his current role as an Associate Professor in 2022. Before joining KAUST, Huser received his Ph.D. degree in statistics from the Swiss Federal

University of Lausanne (EPFL) in 2013. He also holds a B.Sc. in mathematics and an M.Sc. in applied mathematics from EPFL. Huser has received several awards for his research work, including the 2014 EPFL Doctorate Award; the 2015 Lambert Award from the Swiss Statistical Association; the 2019 ENVR Early Investigator Award from the Section on Statistics and the Environment (ENVR) of the American Statistical Association (ASA); and more recently the 2022 Abdel El-Shaarawi Early Investigator Award from The International Environmetrics Society (TIES). He is also an Elected Member of the International Statistical Institute (ISI), and is currently serving as an Associate Editor for five top-tier statistics journals. Huser's research focuses on the development of new flexible and theoretically-motivated statistical models, as well as computationally efficient statistical machine learning inference methods, for extreme events in complex systems arising in various applications from climate and earth sciences, (crypto-)finance, and neuroscience. His work aims at making an impact in statistics of extremes and beyond, by improving models, prediction, and quantification of risk based on high-dimensional, multivariate and/or spatio-temporal, non-stationary datasets.

Dr. Huiyan Sang
Texas A&M University, College Station



Huiyan Sang is a professor and the director of the undergraduate program in statistics at Texas A&M University. She joined Texas A&M in 2008 as an assistant professor after earning her Ph.D. in Statistics from Duke University. Her research interests include the development of theory, methodology, and computation for spatial statistics, graph and network data analysis, Bayesian statistics, machine learning methods, and extreme values. Her interdisciplinary research spans applications of statistics in environmental sciences, geosciences, biomedical research, and engineering.

Huiyan has served on the editorial boards of statistical journals, including AOAS and CSDA, and as a program chair for the ASA Section on Bayesian Statistical Science (SBSS). She has received numerous grants from the National Science Foundation (NSF), the National Institutes of Health (NIH), and industrial partners. In 2018, she received an Early Investigator Award from the American Statistical Association Section on Statistics and the Environment (ENVR). In 2024, she was elected as a Fellow of the American Statistical Association.